

**An Excellent Conceited
Tragedie
of
Lila**

Dramatis Personae

- Daniel, keeper of Galleria d'Aniæl
- Lila, an art student
- Camille, a dancer of the Foyer de la Danse
- Moïse, a street puppeteer and family friend
- Puck, an art student and metamorphic seducer
- Rosaline, Daniel's former wife, present through art and memory
- Lawrence, lawyer to Lila's family
- The Deputy
- The Judge
- Queen Mab
- Queen Titania
- Chorus of Fae, Models, Guests, Officers, and Court

Motifs

- A Muse Meant For Me: Daniel's seduction, art-hunger, and self-excuse.
- The Wager: Mab and Titania's frame; mortal love under supernatural surveillance.
- The Scarf: proof, false resurrection, and the thing evidence cannot explain.
- If I Cannot Have You: Daniel's dangerous transformation of love into art.
- The Greatest Thing: Camille's hidden love, first as absence, finally as uneasy survival.
- Monotone Law: legal speech sung against the orchestra, stripping lyric from life.

Prologue: The Wager

Dark. A bare stage. Above it, the faint outline of a gallery, a bedroom window, a runway, and a courtroom, all suspended like sets not yet lowered.

The Chorus of Fae breathes one syllable: love.

MAB:

Titania, wake. The mortals light their rooms.
They hang their little heavens on the wall.
They call it art when hunger learns to bloom;
they call it love when hunger risks a fall.

TITANIA:

I know their kind. They vow, they touch, they tire.
Their oaths are ribbons tied to weathered doors.
The first hard rain will put away their fire;
the second teaches them to call it yours.

MAB:

Then let us wager.

TITANIA:

On whom?

MAB:

On these.

The gallery lowers into light: Galleria d'Anizæl, ready for Rosaline's fairy exhibition.

MAB:

A keeper of pictures.

TITANIA:

A girl at the threshold.

MAB:

A dancer who knows how to love from the wings.

TITANIA:

A boy with a puppet and poison for strings.

MAB:

If love survives report, law, absence, and shame,

I win.

TITANIA:

If love becomes theater, evidence, name,
I win.

CHORUS OF FAE:

Write it in air.
Write it in breath.
Let one false death
teach love what it is.

MAB and TITANIA:

Begin.

Wager
q. = 76



then let us wa- ger

The bare stage answers with two figures: Lila at the threshold, Puck at the edge of the light. They arrive already theatrical, as if the world has finally found the form it was rehearsing.

CHORUS OF FAE:

Name after breath.
Name after wound.
Name when the record
learns to be sung.

MAB:

In opera, life must pass through fire.

TITANIA:

Keep what was done.
Change what can sing.

MAB:

Lila, step forward.

LILA:

I am not your exhibit.
I am not your proof.

I am the name that rises
when the record finds a roof.

TITANIA:

Puck, trouble the measure.

PUCK:

I am the friend,
the fault,
the foot wrong in the measure.

Call me Puck:

I make a truth
by damaging the pleasure.

DANIEL, unseen:

Then what am I?

MAB:

The one who wanted life as art.

TITANIA:

The one who must hear what art costs.

Act I: The Færie Fæte

Scene 1: Galleria d'Aniæl

Rosaline's paintings glow under gallery lamps. Guests enter in fairy masks.
Daniel moves among them as host, priest, and suspect.

CHORUS OF GUESTS:

Here is the room where old love dries,
framed in gilt and candleflies.
Here is the man who kept the key;
here is the art that set him free.

DANIEL:

Welcome, bright strangers, to Galleria d'Aniæl.
Tonight my former life returns in color.
Rosaline's hand has made a court of loss,
and I, who lost her, keep the door.

CHORUS:

He keeps the door.
He keeps the door.

DANIEL:

Do not mistake me for a mourner.
Beauty has absolutions grief cannot afford.
If art forgives the hand that frames it,
perhaps the living may forgive me too.

Enter Lila and Moïse.

LILA:

So this is Daniel.

MOÏSE:

So this is bait.

LILA:

You promised not to spit on wonder.

MOÏSE:

I promised nothing of the kind.
I know the smell of varnished danger.

I know old men who call desire a studio.

LILA:

He is not old.

MOÏSE:

He is old enough to have a past
and young enough to use it.

DANIEL sees LILA. The orchestra catches the first phrase of A Muse Meant For Me.

A Muse Meant For Me

q=72

The musical notation is on a single staff with a treble clef and a 4/4 time signature. The key signature has one flat (B-flat). The melody consists of five notes: A (quarter), muse (quarter), meant (quarter), for (quarter), and me (half). The notes are written on the staff with their corresponding lyrics below them.

A muse meant for me

DANIEL:

You are looking at the blue one.

LILA:

It looks like a door under water.

DANIEL:

That is exactly what she meant.

LILA:

Rosaline?

DANIEL:

Rosaline.

LILA:

Then you still understand her.

DANIEL:

Understanding is not possession.
I learned that late.

MOÏSE:

Late lessons are expensive for the young.

DANIEL:

And you are?

MOÏSE:

Moïse. Puppeteer. Family friend. Professional warning.

LILA:

Moïse.

DANIEL:

Then warn well. Bad warnings make bad myths.

Scene 2: A Muse Meant For Me

DANIEL remains alone before Rosaline's blue painting. Lila watches from across the gallery.

DANIEL:

Amusement, they say, is a lesser art:

a bell, a trick, a paper crown.

But muse is hidden in amusement's heart,
the angel wearing motley down.

A muse meant for me?

No. Do not say it.

The phrase is too neat,
the wound too willing.

Yet there she stands
where the blue door opens,
not mine, not named,
not even listening.

I have been loved and found unfit.

I have been judged by kinder eyes.

If beauty comes again, let it
come armed. Let it be wise.

LILA approaches.

LILA:

Was that rehearsed?

DANIEL:

Unfortunately, no.

LILA:

Then you should rehearse less often.

DANIEL:

And you should be careful. Compliments are doors.

LILA:

I like doors.

MAB, unseen:

She likes doors.

TITANIA, unseen:

And he keeps keys.

Scene 3: Fae Dance

The guests dance. Masks multiply. Moïse tries to pull Lila away; Daniel offers his hand. Among the masked guests, one figure keeps arriving a half-beat early. It is Puck, not yet named.

CHORUS OF FAE:

Step through the ring,
step through the name,
all mortal music
begins as a game.

LILA:

If I dance, Moïse will sulk.

MOÏSE:

I am already sulking.

DANIEL:

Then nothing is lost.

PUCK, masked:

Step where the room
steps before you.
Call it choice.
Call it cue.

LILA:

Who said that?

DANIEL:

Only the room.
Dancing makes every wall talk.

They dance. Puck cuts between partners, turns Lila a beat too soon, and places her directly into Daniel's arms. Moïse reaches for her and catches only a strip of silk. The room laughs as if nothing happened. Camille appears at the edge of the room, costumed but not masked.

CAMILLE:

He has found a new light.
How quickly a room betrays me.

PUCK, masked:

One face for the guests.
One face for the gate.
One face for the hand
that arrives half a beat late.

MAB:

The dancer sees first.

TITANIA:

The dancer always pays.

Scene 4: The Opera Within The Opera

The gallery transforms into an opera house. Mab and Titania appear openly now, though the mortals treat them as part of the entertainment.

MAB:

Let mortals sit below and watch us judge them.

TITANIA:

They love most safely when the stage is far.

MAB:

I choose the girl.

TITANIA:

I choose the wound.

MAB:

I choose the one who enters.

TITANIA:

I choose the one pursued.

MAB and TITANIA:

Let love be tested by absence.

Let rumor dress as care.

Let law learn lyric.

Let a scarf become prayer.

LILA:

Daniel, is every opera this personal?

DANIEL:

Only the honest ones.

Scene 5: Foyer de la Danse

After the performance. Camille greets Daniel and Lila.

CAMILLE:

Daniel. You brought the moon indoors.

DANIEL:

Camille.

CAMILLE:

No, do not say my name like apology.

I am not so poor.

LILA:

You danced beautifully.

CAMILLE:

That is the curse of dancing.

Everyone can see the body behave
and no one can see what it costs.

DANIEL:

Camille is incapable of a false entrance.

CAMILLE:

And Daniel is incapable of leaving a woman unstoried.

LILA:

Is that praise?

CAMILLE:

It is a map.

Scene 6: The Greatest Thing That Never Was

Camille alone.

CAMILLE:

The greatest thing that never was
still takes its seat beside me.
It does not knock. It does not plead.
It has no hands to guide me.
I loved him first by not confessing,
kept him clean by standing far.
Some women win by being chosen;
some become the evening star.
If she loves him, let her love him.
If he harms her, let me know.
I have learned the art of watching
what I cannot undergo.

CHORUS OF FAE:

Never was.
Never was.
The wound that sings
because it never was.

Act II: Household Law

Scene 1: The Confession

Lila's family home. The gallery light is gone; everything is smaller.

LILA:

Mother. Father.

I have brought a name home.

MOTHER:

Names are not brought home.

They are introduced.

FATHER:

Or hidden.

LILA:

Daniel.

MOTHER:

The gallery man.

FATHER:

The divorced one.

LILA:

The living one.

MOTHER:

Love is generous at the beginning.

It lends the beloved virtues

he has not earned.

FATHER:

How old?

LILA:

Old enough for everyone to ask.

FATHER:

Then old enough.

ENSEMBLE: Household Law

MOTHER:

A daughter is a door.
If she stands open,
weather enters wearing silk.

FATHER:

A house must guard its door.
Love arrives as courtesy
and leaves accounting.

LILA:

I am not a door.
I am the one
who walks through it.
Do not build a house from me
and call the locking love.

MOTHER:

When you were small,
you burned with fever.
I sat at the bed
and counted each breath.

FATHER:

When you were small,
you ran toward traffic.
I learned that fear
can wear a steady face.

MOTHER:

Safety first.

FATHER:

Shut the door.

MOTHER and FATHER, overlapping:

Household Law

q=76

The musical notation is on a single staff with a treble clef. It begins with a large 'G' and a '4' indicating the key and time signature. The melody consists of eighth and quarter notes. The lyrics 'Safe- ty shut the call it care' are written below the staff, with hyphens indicating overlapping syllables between 'Safe-' and 'ty', and 'call' and 'it'.

Safe- ty shut the call it care

Safety first.
Shut the door.
Call it wisdom.
Call it care.

LILA, over them:

Call it fear
teaching my mouth
to borrow your breath.

MOTHER and FATHER:

We kept you living.

LILA:

You kept me legible.

Scene 2: Moïse's Warning

Moïse enters with a puppet wrapped in black cloth.

MOÏSE:

Forgive me. I came because silence would make me guilty.

LILA:

You came because jealousy found a moral costume.

MOÏSE:

Yes. And because costumes can still tell truth.

He lifts the puppet: a little gallery owner with painted hands.

MOÏSE:

See how he bows. See how he praises.

See how the string is never in his hand

until you try to leave.

LILA:

You make him monstrous because I love him.

MOÏSE:

No. I make him visible.

ENSEMBLE:

MOTHER:

A daughter is a door.

FATHER:

A house must guard its door.

MOÏSE:

A lover is a string.

LILA:

I am neither door nor string.

CHORUS:

Guard her.

Warn her.

Name him.

Frame him.

Scene 3: Bedroom Aria

Lila is locked in her room. Moonlight. Mab and Titania watch from the window frame.

LILA:

They have mistaken walls for wisdom.

They have mistaken love for theft.

They say a room can keep me whole
as though my body has not left.

Daniel, do not come.

Daniel, come.

Daniel, forget me.

Daniel, prove them wrong.

What is a girl when everyone
has made her safety into song?

What is a heart that must defend
the hand it reaches toward?

If he is danger, let me know it.

If he is false, let me see.

Do not save me into blindness.

Do not blind me and call it free.

No. I will not be guarded
into someone else's peace.

No. I will not be rescued
as a portrait under glass.

I wanted the door.

I wanted the night beyond it.

I wanted the hand,
and the risk in the hand,
and the name my wanting made.

Let me be wrong with a voice.

Let me be young without vanishing.

Let me desire without becoming
the lesson men sing over me.

If love is fire,

let me know the flame.

If love is theater,
let me choose my name.

MAB:

She asks for sight.

TITANIA:

Sight is never kind.

Act III: Puck

Scene 1: The Sympathetic Stranger

A garden beside the art school. Puck enters as if he has been listening for years.

PUCK:

You are Lila.

You are little,
legal,
late.

You are the girl at the gallery gate.

You are the name
they keep trying
to pronounce for you.

LILA:

That depends who is asking.

PUCK:

A friend of concern.
A concern of friends.
A friendly wound.
A calendar with shoes on.

LILA:

Concern has been very crowded lately.

PUCK:

Then let me stand at the back.
I know Daniel's kind.
He makes women into evidence
that he is capable of beauty.

LILA:

You speak like Moïse with better shoes.

PUCK:

Better shoes,
borrowed voice,

Moïse's warning,
Daniel's choice.
Moïse fears losing you.
I fear you will lose yourself.

Listen for me:

half-step,
bright leap,
falling answer.
That is how a straight line learns
it was never straight.

LILA:

And what do you want?

PUCK:

To be believed before he is forgiven again.
To step where the music thinks it is safe.
To make the straight line trip.

Scene 2: Lila's Lie

Daniel and Lila meet between gallery and street.

DANIEL:

Your letters have grown shorter.

LILA:

My house has grown louder.

DANIEL:

And Puck?

LILA:

A friend.

DANIEL:

That is the word people use
when the truth is still choosing clothes.

LILA:

Do you trust me?

DANIEL:

I am trying to do better than trust.

LILA:

What is better?

DANIEL:

Not owning.

LILA:

Then do not own my answer.

He is a friend.

The orchestra states the Scarf motif for the first time.

Scarf Motif

$q=144$



PUCK, unseen, catches the rhythm. The last two beats of Lila's answer go missing.

Scene 3: The Miscount

The street becomes a rehearsal room without walls. Daniel exits one way; Lila remains. Puck steps into the missing beats as if they were a doorway.

PUCK:

One two three.

One two.

There.

CHORUS OF FAE:

One two three.

One two.

Where?

PUCK:

Where trust should finish,

I begin.

Where promise keeps the measure,

I slip in.

The orchestra tries Daniel's A Muse Meant For Me in four. Puck knocks it into five. The melody limps but keeps its beauty.

Puck Miscount

q = 168

5
G 8

One two three one two

DANIEL, offstage:

A muse meant for me...

PUCK:

No.

A muse meant for weather.

A name meant to flee.

A door with no keeper.

A key without key.

LILA:

Stop bending his song.

PUCK:

I am not bending him.

I am showing you
where he bends you.

CHORUS OF FAE:

Count it again.

Count it again.

Love loses law
when the barline breaks.

LILA:

If I cannot count myself,
someone else will count me.

PUCK:

Then miscount first.

He offers her the scarf. It is less a gift than a new meter.

Scene 4: Seduction Trio

Puck, Lila, and the offstage voice of Daniel's A Muse Meant For Me.

PUCK:

He has given you a myth.

I offer weather.

He gives you measure.

I offer wrong-foot pleasure.

One two three.

One two.

See?

LILA:

Weather ruins things.

DANIEL, offstage:

A muse meant for me,

not for rumor,

not for theft.

PUCK:

Weather tells the truth about roofs.

Weather tells.

Roofs lie.

Names swell.

Names die.

DANIEL, offstage:

A muse meant for me...

LILA:

Do not sing at me from another room.

Do not make absence

another form of claim.

PUCK:

Hear him? Even absent,

he makes you rhyme with him.

Listen: me, thee, free, be.

Pretty cage.

Golden key.

DANIEL, nearer:

Lila, if I have harmed you,
let the harm be mine to hear.
Do not let a stranger
turn your fear into his mirror.

LILA:

Stop.
Stop pulling my name
from opposite doors.
One of you wants memory.
One of you wants weather.
Neither of you knows
what it costs to be the room.

PUCK:

Say your own name.

LILA:

Lila.

PUCK:

Again.

LILA:

Lila.

DANIEL, at threshold:

Not mine, not named...

PUCK:

He named you by refusing to.
I unname by touching.
I touch by refusing the beat.

LILA:

Do not be kind to me.

PUCK:

I am not kind.
I am interval.

I am the note between no and yes.

I am the scarf before evidence.

Remember the shape:

half-step,

bright leap,

falling answer.

You will hear me

when the room pretends to count.

DANIEL, at threshold:

If you leave the measure,

I lose the road to you.

LILA:

Then lose it.

I will not be the path

either of you walks by right.

Daniel has appeared at the threshold without crossing it. Lila sees him only after the refusal. Puck smiles as if this, too, were part of the meter.

They kiss. Mab turns away; Titania watches. Daniel remains at the threshold, hearing the choice as wound and warning.

Scene 5: Daniel's Silence Aria

Daniel alone with an unanswered message.

DANIEL:

To text, to call, to stand beneath a window,
to be the shape her family warned her of.

To wait, to rot, to dignify the silence,
to call that dignity love.

If I go, I prove them.

If I stay, I lose her.

If I speak, I frighten.

If I do not, I accuse her.

What monster wears my outline?

What rumor has my face?

What tenderness becomes a trespass
when it stands too long in place?

Do not answer, Lila.

No. Answer.

No. Be free.

No. Remember.

No. Return.

No. Be done with me.

Act IV: False Death And Fæshion

Scene 1: Lawrence's Counsel

Family house. Lawrence enters with papers that look like music.

LAWRENCE:

The law is not a sword.

It is a stage direction.

It tells bodies where to stand.

FATHER:

Can it make him stop?

LAWRENCE:

It can teach his longing to incriminate itself.

MOTHER:

Say plainly.

LAWRENCE:

Let Lila vanish.

Let him believe what grief believes.

Let every call, every visit, every refusal to accept the story
become a note in the state's music.

LILA:

You want me dead enough to trap him,
alive enough to testify.

LAWRENCE:

I want you safe.

LILA:

No. You want a clean plot.

LAWRENCE:

Plots are how courts understand pain.

Scene 2: The False Death

Daniel receives the note.

DANIEL:

Dead?

No.

CHORUS, whispering:

Dead.

DANIEL:

Ink is not a body.

Paper is not breath.

A family can write anything
and call the writing death.

CHORUS:

Believe.

Accept.

Withdraw.

Repent.

DANIEL:

If love obeys a letter,
then love was never love.
If grief is now forbidden,
what court sits above?

MAB:

He will not accept the fiction.

TITANIA:

Then fiction will become law.

Scene 3: If I Cannot Have You

Atelier Nymphet's opening. Runway, cameras, models, ghosts of fairies.

DANIEL:

If I cannot have you,
then I will be you.
Not flesh. Not voice.
Not the locked room of your choice.
I will be the color
you would have chosen.
I will be the hem
your hand left open.
If I cannot touch you,
I will cut and sew.
If I cannot know you,
I will make not-knowing glow.

CHORUS OF MODELS:

Fæshion, Fæshion,
the wound learns line.
Fæshion, Fæshion,
grief goes divine.

CAMILLE watches him and understands the danger before anyone else.

CAMILLE:

Daniel, come back from the mirror.

DANIEL:

This is not a mirror.
This is resurrection.

Scene 4: The Scarf

Lila enters masked, wearing Puck's scarf. She watches the success of Atelier Nymphet and is wounded by the fact that the world did not stop.

LILA:

They are laughing.

PUCK:

Let them.

LILA:

He is alive.

PUCK:

Did you want him dead?

LILA:

I wanted him ruined enough to prove I mattered.

PUCK:

Then leave him a relic.

Lila removes the scarf and leaves it where Daniel must find it.

DANIEL:

This color.

CAMILLE:

Daniel.

DANIEL:

She is alive.

CAMILLE:

Or someone wants you to sing that in public.

DANIEL:

She is alive.

CHORUS:

Evidence.

Relic.

Trap.

Proof.

MAB:

A scarf can save him.

TITANIA:

A scarf can hang him.

Scene 5: The Deputy

Lila at the station.

DEPUTY:

You do not need to convince me.

I have disliked him for years.

LILA:

That is not justice.

DEPUTY:

It is experience wearing a badge.

LILA:

He believed I was dead.

DEPUTY:

And would not leave the dead alone.

LILA:

I was not dead.

DEPUTY:

That is your complication.

His crime is simpler.

LILA:

What crime?

DEPUTY:

Refusal. Pursuit. The old male art
of calling trespass love.

LILA:

And if we made the maze?

DEPUTY:

Then he should have known better than to run.

Act V: Monotone Law

Scene 1: Birthday Arrest

Daniel's birthday. Camille dances with him. For a moment, the opera almost allows happiness.

CAMILLE:

Take the measure. One, two, turn.

Let the room be only room.

DANIEL:

You are kind to me.

CAMILLE:

No. I am exact.

DANIEL:

Is that better?

CAMILLE:

It lasts longer.

They dance.

CHORUS OF GUESTS:

Birthday candles, gallery light,
hold him briefly, hold him bright.

Officers enter.

OFFICER:

Daniel, you are under arrest.

DANIEL:

For what?

OFFICER:

Stalking. Harassment. Refusal to cease contact.

DANIEL:

With a woman I was told was dead?

OFFICER:

Tell it to the court.

CAMILLE:

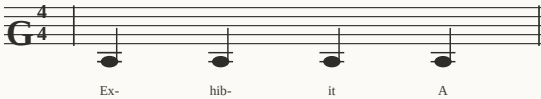
They always say that
as if courts were built to hear.

Scene 2: The Trial

Courtroom. The orchestra is lush; the Prosecutor speaks in a deliberate monotone on one pitch.

Monotone Law

$q=72$



Ex- hib- it A

PROSECUTOR:

The state submits the defendant's own words.

The Clerk places three sheets on a stand. They look like music and are stamped like evidence.

CLERK:

Exhibit A: song.

Exhibit B: message.

Exhibit C: appearance.

PROSECUTOR:

Do not sing them.

Number them.

PROSECUTOR:

"If I cannot have you, then I will be you."

The court repeats it, stripped of music.

COURT CHORUS:

If I cannot have you,

then I will be you.

DANIEL:

That was a song.

PROSECUTOR:

Exactly.

COURT CHORUS:

Exactly.

CLERK:

Exhibit A.

COURT CHORUS:

A.

CLERK:

Possession in lyric form.

DANIEL:

No.

PROSECUTOR:

Exhibit B.

He reads a message as if every word were the same word.

PROSECUTOR:

Are you safe.

Are you there.

Answer me.

Please.

COURT CHORUS:

Safe.

There.

Answer.

Please.

DANIEL:

There was a death notice.

CLERK:

Exhibit C.

COURT CHORUS:

Window.

Street.

Gallery.

Door.

DANIEL:

I did not enter.

PROSECUTOR:

The law also hears standing.

PROSECUTOR:

He received notice.

He disbelieved it.

He searched.

He wrote.

He appeared.

He transformed obsession into public spectacle.

DANIEL:

She was alive.

PROSECUTOR:

The law does not require the fiction
to be true.

It requires the order to be clear.

Lila is called.

JUDGE:

Lila, speak plainly.

LILA:

Plain speech is how we made this mess.

JUDGE:

Speak.

LILA:

I let them write my death.

I let him grieve a lie.

I wore another man's scarf
and watched him come alive.

I wanted him guilty.

I wanted him freed.

I wanted the world to name the wound
without naming me.

JUDGE:

Did he frighten you?

LILA:

Yes.

DANIEL:

Lila.

LILA:

And so did my parents.

And so did Puck.

And so did the kindness
that made me vanish for my own good.

JUDGE:

Did he stop?

LILA:

No.

Silence.

Scene 3: Verdict Ensemble

JUDGE:

The court cannot judge love.
The court can judge conduct.
The court cannot sing motive.
The court can count steps.
Daniel rises.

DANIEL:

Then count them.
Count gallery to street.
Count street to window.
Count letter to silence.
Count every door I did not enter.
Count every song I should not have sung.

LILA:

Then count this too.

Verdict Count
q=72

Then count this too count the house

Count the death they taught me
to wear like decent clothing.
Count the house that called it safety.
Count the kindness that made lying
look like breath.

COURT CHORUS:

Count.
Count.
Count.
Count.

MOTHER and FATHER enter at the back of the court, not as witnesses but
as people who can no longer remain language alone.

MOTHER:

Safety first.

FATHER:

Shut the door.

MOTHER:

I learned your breath
before I learned your grammar.
I held the fever-count
like prayer in the dark.

FATHER:

I learned your danger
before I learned your will.
I made a steady mask
and called that steadiness love.

MOTHER and FATHER:

Safety first.
Shut the door.
Call it wisdom.
Call it care.

JUDGE:

Order.

MAB:

There is no order.
There is only rhythm
mistaking itself for law.

TITANIA:

And law mistaking itself
for innocence.

JUDGE:

Guilty.

The word breaks into the orchestra. Mab and Titania appear above the court.

The ensemble begins to overlap.

COURT CHORUS:

Guilty.

Guilty.
Count the steps.
Keep the score.

MAB:

Human court:
guilty of pursuit,
of pressure,
of the act that can be named.

TITANIA:

Fae court:
guilty of asking beauty
to acquit appetite,
and calling that hunger love.

MOTHER:
A daughter is a door.

FATHER:
A house must guard its door.

MAB:
He loved.

TITANIA:
He pursued.

MAB:
He was deceived.

TITANIA:
He desired to be deceived.

MAB:
He was warned.

TITANIA:
He made a theater
of not hearing.

MAB:
She was caged.

TITANIA:

She was cruel.

LILA:

I was afraid.

DANIEL:

I was blind.

COURT CHORUS, under all:

Afraid.

Blind.

Guilty.

Still.

MOTHER and FATHER:

Safety first.

Shut the door.

MOTHER and FATHER:

We kept you living.

We kept the door.

MAB:

And he kept a mirror
where a woman stood.

TITANIA:

He asked her answer
to pardon his design.

LILA:

You kept the ledger
of each permitted breath.
You kept the child
and taught the woman absence.

MOTHER:

We feared the weather.

FATHER:

We feared the street.

MOTHER:

We feared your vanishing.

FATHER:

We feared our names
would fail to bring you back.

MOTHER and FATHER:

Fear learned your face
and spoke in ours.

LILA:

You kept me legible.
No more doors.
No borrowed names.
No more houses
built from my fear.

PUCK, entering within the broken overlap:

Then break the house
without denying the hands
that built it.
Break the count.
Keep the pulse.

MOTHER:

If I release the door,
what am I?

LILA:

A mother with open hands.

FATHER:

If I release the law,
what am I?

PUCK:

A father after measure:

still there,
but no longer the lock.

MOTHER and FATHER, wavering into new rhythm:

We kept you living.

LILA:

Then keep me living now.

Not hidden.

Not corrected.

Seen.

MOTHER and FATHER:

Seen.

MAB:

Then who wins?

TITANIA:

No one. That is why mortals invented theater.

Scene 4: The Greatest Thing That Ever Was

Outside the court. Camille waits. Daniel is not free, but he is briefly unperformed. The sound of the courtroom has not vanished; it follows as residue.

DANIEL:

Camille.

CAMILLE:

Do not make that a refuge.

Do not turn toward me

because the other door closed.

CAMILLE:

Because the greatest thing that never was

The Greatest Thing

h=52



has changed its cruel tense.

Not into triumph. Not reward.

Into witness.

DANIEL:

I have very little left.

CAMILLE:

Good.

Then perhaps you will stop mistaking abundance for love.

They do not kiss. Not yet.

CAMILLE:

The greatest thing that ever was

may not arrive in glory.

DANIEL:

It may stand outside the court

and refuse to end the story.

Lila and Puck enter before the cadence settles. They are no longer distant. Camille hears them first and steps aside without surrendering witness; Daniel follows later. Behind them, Mother and Father have emerged from the court doors, changed but not absolved.

LILA:

No borrowed doors.

PUCK:

No measured names.

No borrowed measure.

No count without breath.

LILA:

I keep the breath

they taught to lie.

PUCK:

I break the count

that made it shame.

CAMILLE:

Witness, then.

Not blessing.

Not claim.

DANIEL:

Changed.

Not mine.

MOTHER:

No shuttered breath.

FATHER:

No guarded name.

MOTHER and FATHER:

We keep you living

with open hands.

LILA and PUCK:

We leave by the interval

alive, unframed.

Not pure. Not pardoned.
Changed, not reclaimed.

CHORUS:

Alive.
Unframed.

CHORUS:

Ever was.
Never was.
Love survives
changed, not pure.

CAMILLE and WITNESS CHORUS:

Witness.

DANIEL:

Not mine.

MOTHER and FATHER:

Seen.
Still.

DANIEL, low:

Changed.
The last human sonority does not close. It remains suspended in the air the
fae must inherit.

Epilogue: Wager Unpaid

Mab and Titania return to the bare stage.

MAB:

I said love would survive.

TITANIA:

It did not survive unchanged.

MAB:

Nothing living does.

TITANIA:

Then what did we prove?

MAB:

That we were listening
for verdicts
and got weather.

TITANIA:

That they left the frame
more alive than our wager.

MAB:

That love can be evidence
without becoming law.

TITANIA:

That law can count breath
and still fail to keep it.

Upstage, Lila does not turn back. Puck removes the scarf from his own neck
and leaves it hanging on nothing.

The Chorus of Fae repeats the first syllable, now divided:

CHORUS:

Love.

Law.

Love.

Law.

Love.

Alive.

MAB:

No winner, then.

TITANIA:

No. Only witness
after measure.

CHORUS:

Alive.

Unframed.

Changed.

Still.

PUCK, almost laughing:

Wrong count.

Blackout.